

(Un)caged by tech

Whenever we embrace technology in our lives, it's important to be absolutely clear on how that piece of tech is going to ultimately impact the way we live. How it makes a difference not just on day 1 but also weeks, months and even years down the road. Because after all, technology can be liberating, bringing about a world of possibilities, enriching our life with convenience and freeing us to concentrate on other things we'd likely want to do. At least in principle.

Take for example, the matter of elders in our home or extended family. Without modern electronics, from hearing aids to pill dispensers, and access to devices like smartphones and tablets, our elders would have faced immense challenges to not just survive but also thrive as they grow older. If you read some of the brilliant advice given by Agent 001 in this month's cover story, all attempts to make elder-friendly tech even more accessible and convenient, you'll know how crucial technology and tech gadgets have become for the emotional well-being of elders in the family. For giving them a sense of belonging and togetherness with the rest of the family.

A senior lady from our extended family, one of my aunts who's well into her seventies, had come to visit my mother in 2021 after a long time. With the pandemic still raging, acutely aware of how fragile life can be, and how we need to make the most of our time together, my mother recommended my aunt to upgrade her dumb feature phone to an Android smartphone. She explained how my aunt can not only use WhatsApp to send and receive messages, video or voice call loved ones, but also watch live TV channels and old movies on YouTube all in the comfort of her palm. For my aunt, who divides her time between Mumbai and her native village, shifting to an Android smartphone wasn't exactly easy. We had to handhold her like a small child, teaching her everything from how to use WhatsApp for different modes of communication and searching old movies on YouTube. But once she got to grips with her new smartphone and its range of possibilities, there was no looking back.



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From listening to bhajans in the morning to catching up on daily TV soaps, voice searching YouTube content and video calling friends and family, even subscribing to an OTT app just to be able to play Crorepati while watching the episode in real-time, my aunt's ability to easily communicate with anyone and daily dose of entertainment was greatly enhanced thanks to modern technology-powered smartphone, internet and a few essential apps. Not only was my aunt happy with her new tech-fuelled reality, but so was my mother – who could now easily stay in touch with her from whenever and wherever. For all practical purposes, shifting to a smartphone had a hugely positive and liberating effect on my aunt, at least for half a year or so.

Fast forward to 2023, when the same aunt came to visit us earlier this summer, my mom was mildly shocked to see her descent into smartphone addiction. Not only was my aunt viewing content at very loud volume levels, she was also staying up late into the wee hours of the night, consuming everything that YouTube and her OTT apps had to offer. Unbeknownst to her, the drastic lifestyle change due to the smartphone was disrupting her sleeping patterns and adversely impacting her eyes, ears and overall health. We had to persuade her to use the smartphone, and its world of possibilities, a lot more prudently – for her own well-being. I mean even my daughter, who doesn't know when to stop watching YouTube if left unsupervised, was asking my aunt to restrict her phone use down to a bare minimum. The irony!

Without a doubt access to technology and tech products can be liberating and life-changing, I know it firsthand. ChatGPT is a great tool to help me do more in less time, but I can't be fully at its mercy. I'm always aware that by adopting it into my workflow it cannot replace the writer in me. Because if it does, who's left behind? When we dive headlong into adopting any technology in our life, be it for personal or professional use, it's important to keep checking whether you're in fact truly free or caged by it. **d**